4
FIRST RESPONSES

13 MARCH 2020

INDIA | 70 ACTIVE CASES | 2 DEATHS

WORLD | 1,01,266 ACTIVE CASES | 5,446 DEATHS

A global religious Muslim organization, the Tablighi Jamaat held a mass congregation of over 9,000 missionaries at New Delhi's Banglewadi Nizamuddin Markaz centre in the first two weeks of March.[1] Thousands of people, including various preachers and attendees who had only the previous month gathered in Malaysia for a four-day global meet which *The New York Times* reported at the time as 'the largest viral vector in Southeast Asia'[2] made their way to the Nizamuddin Markaz. These included 800 preachers from Indonesia, Bangladesh, Malaysia and Thailand who entered the country on 'tourist visas' which categorically do not allow missionary work to be undertaken during the time of stay in India. The event in Malaysia had been such a super-spreader that about 620 people connected to the event had tested positive due to which Malaysia had to quickly seal its borders. Travel restrictions were not initiated then, owing to very low caseload in India, due to which thousands of Indian Muslims belonging to the Tablighi Jamaat from across the country too, made their way to New Delhi for the event.[3]

New information about the virus and its nature of spread was emerging each day. It was learned that during super-spreader events, one infected person had the ability to infect over six people, almost doubling its pervasiveness. However, this number could be volatile and increase dramatically if no COVID-19-appropriate behaviour of masking up or